What could externalising a value mean? Four mechanisms

EXCHANGE

writing frees the workspace

prediction. a written value leaves the workspace until it is reused

DUPLICATION

the page is a redundant backup

prediction. a written value is also held internally across the gap

COMPLEMENTARY

page and workspace hold different content

prediction. CoT values are absent from the direct-mode readout

EPIPHENOMENAL

CoT helps via extra compute, not content

prediction. matched-length filler rescues the ablated model